EVERYONE SEEMS AHEAD. ↗

First-year students misjudge their peers far more than their peers actually influence them.

OUR SURVEY / 53 FIRST-YEAR STUDENTS / OCTOBER 2026

45%
often compare themselves with better-off peers

62%
compare grades and GPA, the top area (tied with soft skills)

58%
say comparing brings self-doubt or low self-worth

11%
would see a counsellor to cope

31%
of first-years screened positive for a mental disorder in the past year

Auerbach et al., 2018

3.02
worry about future competence, the top stress source in Vietnamese first-years (workload 2.87)

Nguyen et al., 2024

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Instructor: **Ms. Trương Thanh Tuyền**

SSA101 · RESEARCH POSTER · GROUP 1

Peer Pressure on Self-Comparison in First-Year University Students

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01 BACKGROUND

At university, grades and friendships start again and social media keeps comparison going after class. Resistance to peer influence changes little from age 18 to 30 (Steinberg & Monahan, 2007), so first-year pressure comes from the new setting rather than from age.

31% of first-year students screened positive for a mental disorder in the past 12 months.
Auerbach et al., 2018 · n = 13,984

02 RESEARCH QUESTIONS

RQ1 How does peer pressure shape self-comparison among first-year students?

RQ2 Which weighs more on comparison: social media use or academic results?

RQ3 How are peer pressure and self-comparison linked to the stress and well-being of first-year students?

03 MIXED METHODS

Quantitative: online survey
53 first-year students took a 19-item Google Form in October 2026.

Qualitative: open-ended answers
22 students answered an optional open question on what would help new students feel less peer pressure.

KEY OPEN-ENDED ANSWERS

> **"Peer pressure is natural. Use it to try harder, because not everyone has the same journey."**
> Khải Luận · Financial

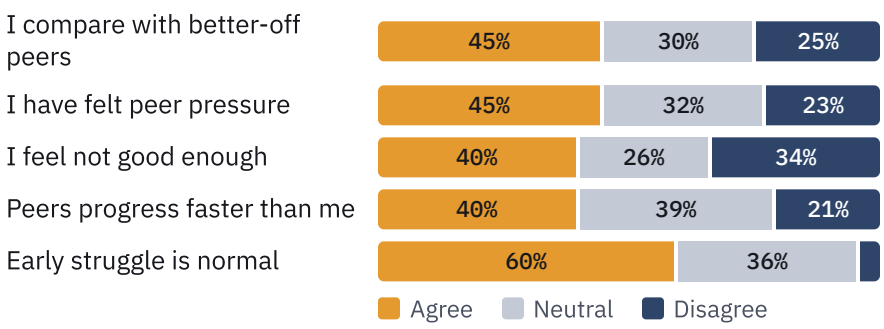
> **"Focus on yourself and accept that you still have weak points. Even 1% better each day is already a change."**
> Thành Long · IT and Engineering

> **"Just be yourself. As long as I am better today than I was yesterday, that is enough."**
> Tường Anh · Media

04 SURVEY RESULTS

n = 53

How students rate each statement



What students compare



More than one answer allowed.

How negative comparison makes them feel



More than one answer allowed.

How students cope



More than one answer allowed.

05 CONCLUSION

RQ1
Nearly **half** of students (45%) often compare themselves with better-off peers and feel peer pressure. The two tend to rise together.

RQ2
Academic results weigh more: grades tie with soft skills as the top point of comparison (62%). More hours on social media did not mean more comparison.

RQ3
Negative comparison brings **self-doubt (58%)** and stress (49%), yet only **1 in 10** would seek help from a counsellor.

References Auerbach, R. P., et al. (2018). *Journal of Abnormal Psychology, 127*(7), 623–638. · Steinberg, L., & Monahan, K. C. (2007). *Developmental Psychology, 43*(6), 1531–1543. · Survey data: Group 1, October 2026.